

Statement of Academic Purpose

With this letter, I would like to express interest in the M.Sc. in *Political Science and Political Economy* at the London School of Economics.

A lingering debt crisis, Brexit, and a global pandemic—the bedrock of European unity is under enormous pressure. As someone with family in Italy and Germany, I witnessed first-hand how these events rippled through the social fabric of both countries, tightening relations and stoking the fires of Euroscepticism. This precarious and turbulent climate is the driver behind my economic and political interests, and I direct most of my intellectual curiosity towards the future of Europe and global capitalism.

My desire to make sense of such multifaceted and complex issues prompted me to pursue a degree in economics. Apart from taking standard economic courses, I used this opportunity to complete electives that aligned more closely with my interests.

For instance, eager to understand the causes of the European debt crisis, I chose the elective *Money, Credit & Banking*. This course expanded my awareness of financial institutions and introduced me to the inherent fragility of money markets. Further, each lecture began with a discussion of the *Financial Times* front page, tying current developments to the concepts discussed in class. These excursions into politics showed me that policy decisions can stray from academic ideas of ‘efficiency’ and I recognized that economic analysis often brushes aside the political nuance of real life. This realization sparked my interest in Political Economy, which I perceive as the bridge between economic abstraction and the nitty-gritty of actual policymaking. In fact, my ambition is to understand the mechanisms by which policymakers reach decisions when divergent interests collide in the political arena. In this regard, electives such as *Politics of Economic Policy* could supplement my economic background and significantly enhance my understanding.

Another course that stirred my interest in Political Economy is *History of Economic Thought*. Previous courses had excised economic theories from their historical contexts, creating a fragmented mental picture of the field. By embedding these fragments into their socio-political background, this course provided the connective tissue to piece together a coherent narrative, and in doing so, transformed my perception of economics. I began to appreciate it as a dynamic field — prone to ideological shifts and tightly pegged to the currents of social and political change. For instance, seeing how food shortages influenced Malthusian theory, or how Marxism was a response to abhorrent labor exploitation, made me realize that economic insights often stem from socio-political predicaments. Just as economic ideas shape our world through their normative prescriptions, so too, the world shapes economic ideas. It is this tug of war between theory and reality that makes politics part and parcel of the economic purview.

Recognizing this connection roused my political interests further and prompted me to take part in the 2019 Model United Nations. There I honed my debating skills and my understanding of international relations through a series of lively debates about the South China Sea dispute. As an economics undergraduate, I was tempted to reduce this conflict to an international clash over factors of production. However, as I engaged with students from different backgrounds, I understood that my insights bordered on superficial truisms; correct, but hardly illuminating. While fundamentally about natural resources, the South China Sea dispute could not be understood without considering the power imbalances and strained political relations between all involved parties. Unfortunately, these vital nuances might get lost in a purely economic approach. Again, this experience strengthened my conviction that a fruitful analysis of reality must be interdisciplinary.

Outside of academic commitments, I enjoy exploring economics and politics through additional reading. Recently, one book in particular — “And The Weak Suffer What They Must” by Yanis Varoufakis — fascinated me due to its interdisciplinary analysis of the European Union. Written by the former finance minister of Greece, this book blends political history, economic theory, and personal anecdote to pinpoint institutional flaws within the European Monetary Union. In doing so, it opened my eyes to the inherent fragility and undemocratic nature of the European Union, both of which could have devastating political consequences. Indeed, as an Italian I saw anti-Europeanism and a wounded national pride coalesce into vicious xenophobia and the fetishization of bygone national glory. Alas, such sentiments are far from an anomaly nowadays, and I fear the European Union might have unwittingly planted a powderkeg deep into its foundation. Defusing this situation will require a deep makeover which can only be achieved through careful analysis of Europe’s institutional shortcomings. The latter is, because of its massive political importance, my biggest area of personal interest and I believe the elective *The Political Economy of European Monetary Integration* could significantly boost my knowledge about the EMU.

Besides economics and politics, I am intrigued by the psychological dimension of modern democracies. This interest was stirred by the 2016 US presidential election which highlighted the irrational and emotion-laden nature of the electoral process. Rather than informed policy discussions, I observed personal scandals and partisan hostility dominate public discourse, amplified by the bullhorns of social media. Among this bombastic frenzy, voters were expected to make level-headed and rational decisions—a very hard ask considering the imperfect information at their disposal. Seeing this reality led me to question the mechanisms by which voters form opinions and the role that media play in this process. Curious to learn more, I stumbled upon the writings of Noam Chomsky whose book “Manufacturing Consent” has been seminal to my thinking. In this scathing critique of the media establishment, Chomsky presents

a five-step propaganda model that delineates the structural biases of mass media and undermines its claims of objectivity. Further, Chomsky briefly covers Walter Lippmann's "Public Opinion"; a famous monograph suggesting that public opinion be controlled through mass media in favor of 'social cohesion'. Both Chomsky's and Lippmann's ideas led me to ponder the extent to which powerful interests mold public opinion, and whether democracy can exist if media power remains unchecked. Such questions have become even more crucial in the age of social media, and I believe the elective *Public Opinion, Political Psychology and Citizenship* would be the ideal opportunity to deepen my understanding of this area.

Lastly, I am driven by an intense desire for a globally oriented climate. I was raised bilingually in the vibrant suburbs of western Germany, sparking my curiosity for foreign cultures at an early age. This background animated me to participate in student exchange programs and internships abroad, to travel extensively in Southeast Asia and finally to pursue a university degree in the Netherlands. In this regard, the London School of Economics with its multicultural student body and its international outlook appears an excellent choice. Indeed, situated in the heart of a cosmopolitan hub, I believe LSE represents the perfect environment to stimulate personal growth—academically, socially, and creatively.

In summary, I am motivated by an ambition to tackle big picture economic questions. I believe that the future will bring complex challenges that require foresight and flexibility, and this belief pushes me towards an interdisciplinary master's degree. My academic aim is not to amass encyclopedic knowledge within a narrow field, rather I want to grow into an analytical thinker that can connect dots on a macro-level. After my studies, I aspire to use my education in an impactful way by working on influential and high-stakes economic challenges, either in academia or in policy analysis. Though I have not settled on a specific path yet, I believe an M.Sc. in Political Science and Political Economy, with its expansive scope and focus on real-world events, is the perfect steppingstone for an intellectually stimulating and socially impactful career.